

Randomised clinical trial: dried plums (prunes) vs. psyllium for constipation.



BACKGROUND: Treatment of chronic constipation remains challenging with 50% of patients dissatisfied with current therapy. There is an unmet need for natural and safe alternatives. Dried plums (prunes) have been used traditionally for constipation but their efficacy is not known. **Aim** To assess and compare the effects of dried plums and psyllium in patients with chronic constipation. **METHODS:** Subjects were enrolled in an 8-week, single-blind, randomised cross-over study. Subjects received either dried plums (50 g b.d., fibre=6 gm/day) or psyllium (11 g b.d., fibre=6 gm/day) for 3 weeks each, in a crossover trial with a 1-week washout period. Subjects maintained a daily symptom and stool diary. Assessments included number of complete spontaneous bowel movements per week, global relief of constipation, stool consistency, straining, tolerability and taste. **RESULTS:** Forty constipated subjects (m/f=3/37, mean age=38 years) participated. The number of complete spontaneous bowel movements per week (primary outcome measure) and stool consistency scores improved significantly ($P<0.05$) with dried plums when compared to psyllium. Straining and global constipation symptoms did not differ significantly between treatments ($P=N.S.$). Dried plums and psyllium were rated as equally palatable and both were safe and well tolerated. **CONCLUSION:** Dried plums are safe, palatable and more effective than psyllium for the treatment of mild to moderate constipation, and should be considered as a first line therapy. © 2011 Blackwell Publishing Ltd.